Ack Dec 8

Ack'd Dec 18.

No 147.

Mr Pratt

U. S. Legation, Japan,
Tokei, November 6th, 1874.

DEPARTMENT OF STATE
RECEIVED
DEC
8
1874

Mr Bingham
to the
Hon. Secretary of State.

Subject.

It is said that Okubo, Japanese Ambassador, has left Peking (26th Sept.) having had a rupture with Chinese Authorities. Mr Avery has conversed with Li-hung-chang, who desires the intervention of the good offices of the U.S. China will guarantee the protection of foreigners in Formosa, but will not pay a war indemnity to Japan, nor allow the latter's claim of a conquest of a portion of Formosa.

No 147.

U. S. Legation, Japan,
Tokei, 6 November, 1874.

Hon. Hamilton Fish,
Secretary of State,
Washington, D.C.

Sir:

I have the honor to say that in an interview with Sir Harry S. Parkes on the 4th inst. he informed me that he had information that the Japanese Envoy, Mr Okubo, and his suite had left Peking on the 26th ultimo by reason of some unexplained difficulty which abruptly terminated negotiations with China. In the "Gazette" of last evening,

evening, published in Yokohama, the same statement is made. I received last evening a private letter from our Minister to China, Mr Avery, dated Tientsin, Oct. 18th, from which I deem it proper to make the following extract:

"I have had two long important interviews with the Viceroy, Li-Hung-Chang, who you know is the ablest and most exalted subject in China × × × × × He was certainly cordial beyond anything I had been lead to expect from a Chinese official of high rank, and gave his opinion on all subjects relating to foreign and domestic affairs

"without

without the least apparent reserve. He plainly invited the good offices of the United States to aid in the settlement of the Formosan trouble, expressing his distrust of other treaty Powers for reasons which he gave in confidence. He said in reply to a suggestive query of mine, that China has distinctly offered to guarantee future and ample protection to Japanese and other strangers in Formosa, to subdue the savages by force, if necessary, to send a Commissioner there, to establish lighthouses on the coast and to indemnify for actual losses of life and property. But she will not give

a

"a war indemnity, nor acknowledge
"the claim of conquest over
"a portion of the island, which
"he says the Japanese now persistently assert. This claim is
"credited to Le Gendre, who has published an anonymous pamphlet
"here in defense of it, and who
"is regarded as the great marplot of the situation. I do not
"think it admissable, and unless
"the Treaty Powers can persuade
"Japan to withdraw it, a
"peaceful settlement will be
"impossible."

Mr Avery says that the foregoing is a hasty and imperfect statement of what he shall report to the Department, but as my despatch will reach you, probably, some time before his, I thought it well to send it forward.

Nothing definite of the present purposes of Japan touching further operations in Formosa can be ascertained from officials here. I inferred from a conversation with Mr Terashima on the 3rd, that the prospect for successful negotiations with China was not promising. He did not intimate, however, what Japan demanded, nor what further hostile demonstrations, if any, will be made upon Formosa. It is publicly reported that Japan is supplying her force in Formosa with

fresh

fresh troops to fill the losses occasioned by death and sickness. It is also said that there is much activity in enforcing the conscription in the various provinces.

I am, Sir,

Your obedient servant,

Jno. A. Bingham